BY THE GLOBAL SOUTH FOR THE GLOBAL SOUTH

RETHINKING DEVELOPMENT THROUGH EVIDENCE

Prajna Naidoo, Evaluation Analyst, Ashwani K. Muthoo, Director General, and Manas Puri, Senior Professional, New Development Bank's Independent Evaluation Office

The Global South is increasingly recognised as a centre of innovation and applied expertise that sustains integral functions of the global economy. Emerging and developing economies account for nearly 90% of the world's primary commodity exports, supplying much of its productive labour and intellectual talent. Africa holds about 30% of global mineral reserves, Asia leads in manufacturing inputs, and Latin America remains a leading exporter of agricultural goods and lithium for clean energy. Yet, value-chain asymmetries persist, and about 80% of value added in global trade continues to be captured elsewhere.

The New Development Bank (NDB) aims to support nationally owned growth and resilience through development finance and partnerships tailored to the needs of emerging economies that maintain the core fabric of the global economy. Within this framework, the Independent Evaluation Office (IEO) provides evidence-based assessments that help the Bank and its members learn from experience, enhance performance, and ensure that results remain relevant to the evolving needs of the Global South.

NDB member countries represent 45% of the global population, with 86% of those populations residing in emerging markets and developing economies, making the NDB a multilateral institution by the Global South, for the Global South. With over 120 projects approved, amounting to USD 40 billion in investments, the bank's influence is already significant.

Evaluation in the Global South requires sensitivity to local realities, using metrics that reflect what progress means within each country's own social, environmental, and institutional framework.

In a decade, the NDB has evolved from an ambitious experiment in South-South finance into a proven platform for shared growth. Its vision rests on a core belief that development is most sustainable when it draws on the wisdom of context and the discipline of evidence. Across its evaluations, the IEO has found that in:

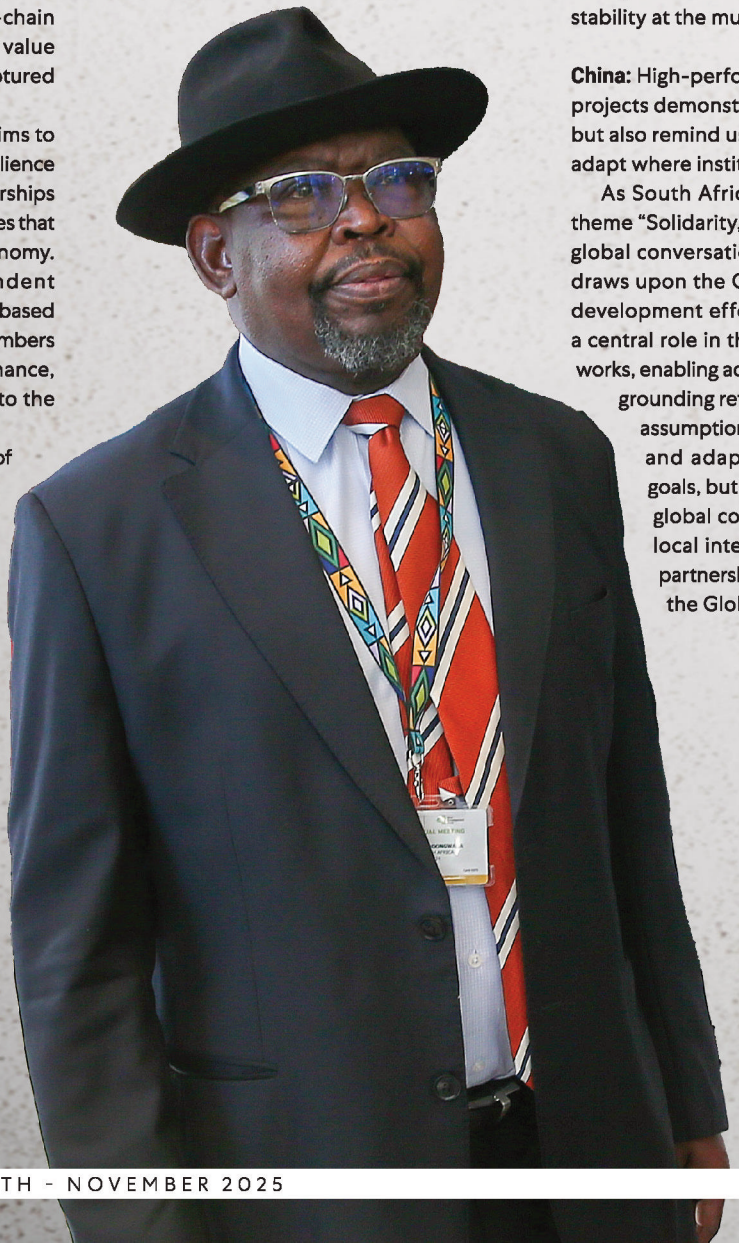
South Africa: Renewable-energy projects expanded capacity and reduced emissions, but they require stronger coordination across national transition strategies that are essential for systemic impact.

India: Road and solar investments have accelerated connectivity and climate goals, although efficiency gaps and procurement delays highlight the need for integrated approaches that holistically address the country's objectives.

Brazil: Co-financed urban programmes illustrate the promise of shared ownership, though sustainability depends on fiscal stability at the municipal level.

China: High-performing infrastructure projects demonstrate excellence in delivery, but also remind us that approaches must adapt where institutional maturity differs.

As South Africa leads the G20 under the theme "Solidarity, Equality, Sustainability," the global conversation on development finance draws upon the Global South as a teacher of development effectiveness. Evaluation plays a central role in this process; identifying what works, enabling adaptation across contexts, and grounding reforms in evidence rather than assumption. It shows that accountability and adaptability are not competing goals, but complementary ones, where global comparability can coexist with local integrity when guided by equal partnership and mutual learning across the Global South and beyond.



South African Finance Minister **Enoch Godongwana**